Let's call her Tanya—a real person to whom we assign a generic name. Perhaps she can stand for a generation. Just 30, she's at an age cusp in more ways than one. Technically a millennial, young enough to be on the Gen Z boundary, old enough to have spent seven years at the financial services firm she joined as a fresher. Part of its 12-person legal team, she handles even complex, time-sensitive cases. "I've earned a rep for turning around work quickly, so I'm usually the first name my boss thinks of when assigning urgent matters," she says. Every deal, contract, sales agreement or client acquisition has to be vetted by the legal team, so it's top-notch work, with plenty to learn. Yet, these days she has quietly taken a back seat, even keeping a distance from colleagues, speaking only when necessary.

At 39, banking professional Sameer has a resume that's twice as long. But as one who hit his teens around Y2K, he's a card-holding digital native too—nimble with his footwork as AI changes his world. He took courses, read voraciously and arrived early on the ball. At the bank where he's been working for over two years, they could rely on him to be the tech ninja, handling dynamite itself: AI-powered cybersecurity. Applause from seniors, visibility, a sense of empowerment, he had it all. Since June, though, Sameer has become like Tanya. He goes to office, does the bare minimum and returns home. He's always "respectful and courteous". He won't "burn bridges". But there's a line in the sand. "I deliver only what's asked of me. Nothing more."

The name for this is 'Quiet Quitting'. At the individual level, it expresses an employee's psychological relationship with work. A predisposition to keeping it low gear, sustenance level—committing oneself to not committing more. Collectively, they are talking of an epidemic of withdrawal. "We speak to over 1,000 candidates almost every day," says Aditya Narayan Mishra, MD and CEO of talent solutions firm CIEL HR. "Anxiety and despondency about the future are very real." The phrase was born on TikTok, in the spring of 2022, and went viral. Recall that time. In the long shadow of COVID-19, office work had colonised all waking hours via WFH. Global conversations had turned to worker burnout; the question of work-life balance never seemed more urgent.

77%

OF INDIA'S EMPLOYEES EITHER 'NOT ENGAGED' OR 'ACTIVELY DISENGAGED'

Source: Gallup's State of the Global Workplace 2026 Report

₹32.7 lakh crore

OR 9% OF GDP: ESTIMATED COST IN LOST ANNUAL PRODUCTIVITY

Source: Gallup estimates

But in India, the phrase acquired an extra layer of depth because of when it entered the lexicon: it was the fourth decade of liberalisation, and a 'second generation' had joined the workforce. This cohort did not receive the idea as inherently a negative. If anything, it helped crystallise a certain scepticism of the insanely careerist ethos peddled since the '90s. A wholesale surrender of the self to the job, in their eyes, meant erosion, effacement and opportunity cost, not the boundless growth promised by the narrative. Quiet quitting made available an alternate model, maybe even a credo to be adopted.

A CASCADING PHENOMENON

Employers are worried. It's an interpretive label, not a formal yardstick, but it's getting invoked in studies of engagement levels. The data isn't rosy. Global consulting firm Gallup's State of the Global Workplace 2026 Report estimates that 59 per cent of employees in India are in 'quiet quitting' mode: they do the basics but have little emotional connect with their work or company. Another 18 per cent are 'actively disengaged'. They are unhappy, frustrated and can even work to harm the company. A rebellious Gen Z isn't the problem here. Gallup records a distinct fall in manager engagement levels in India: from 39 to 30 per cent over 2024-2025. "It's the sharpest decline ever," says Puneet Pratap Singh, regional director, Research and Analytics for APAC, Gallup India. Anger or disgruntlement at the managerial level can cascade downward. Gallup believes at least 70 per cent of the differences in employee engagement levels between business units or teams is directly attributable to the leader.

The phenomenon exacts a high cost. Aggregated across industries, Gallup estimates that employee disengagement costs India Rs 32.7 lakh crore in lost workplace productivity annually, about 9 per cent of its GDP. As the spread effect from managers to juniors suggests, this work ethic has external origins; the causative chain spirals as far out as one can map it. Attitudes do not germinate in the silo of individual brains, only from neurochemistry. The chemistry within an organisation is as key. That, in turn, is affected by the complex business environment of our times, marked by rapid technological obsolescence. Enterprises are as much its victim.

The IT sector, intimately tied to global technology flows, is an exemplar. With AI's advent, employees have entered a state of flux, in which the confusion is amplified by geopolitical complications. Old business models had to be junked post haste, with AI integration forced on companies just to stay relevant. Shareholders, too, are demanding lower operating